

Pythagoric Sentences

ΠΥΘΑΓΟΡΕΙΩΝ ΓΝΩΜΑΙ

Pythagoreans

translated by Thomas Taylor (1818)

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Pythagoric Sentences

Pythagoric Ethical Sentences from Stobæus, Which Are Omitted in the Opuscula Mythologica, &c. of Gale

E.1

Do not even *think* of doing what ought not to be done.

E.2

Choose rather to be strong in soul than in body.

E.3

Be persuaded that things of a laborious nature contribute more than pleasures to virtue.

E.4

Every passion of the soul is most hostile to its salvation.

E.5

It is difficult to walk at one and the same time in many paths of life.¹

E.6

Pythagoras said, it is requisite to choose the most excellent life; for custom will make it pleasant. Wealth is an infirm anchor, glory is still more infirm; and in a similar manner the body, dominion, and honor. For all these are imbecile and powerless. What then are powerful anchors? Prudence, magnanimity, fortitude. These no tempest can shake. This is the law of God, that virtue is the only thing that is strong; and that every thing else is a trifle.

E.7

All the parts of human life, in the same manner as those of a statue, ought to be beautiful.

E.8

A statue indeed standing on its basis, but a worthy man on the subject of his deliberate choice, ought to be immovable.

E.9

Frankincense ought to be given to the Gods, but praise to good men.

E.10

It is requisite to defend those who are unjustly accused of having acted injuriously, but to praise those who excel in a certain good.

E.11

Neither will the horse be judged to be generous, that is sumptuously adorned, but the horse whose nature is illustrious; nor is the man worthy who possesses great wealth, but he whose soul is generous.

E.12

When the wise man opens his mouth, the beauties of his soul present themselves to the view, like the statues in a temple.²

E.13

Remind yourself that all men assert that wisdom is the greatest good, but that there are few who strenuously endeavour to obtain this greatest good.³ Pythagoras.

E.14

Be sober, and remember to be disposed to believe; for these are the nerves of wisdom. Epicharmus.

E.15

It is better to live lying on the grass, confiding in divinity and yourself, than to lie on a golden bed with perturbation.

E.16

You will not be in want of any thing, which it is in the power of Fortune to give and take away.⁴

E.17

Despise all those things, which when liberated from the body you will not want; and exercising yourself in those things of which when liberated from the body you will be in want, invoke the Gods to become your helpers.⁵

E.18

Neither is it possible to conceal fire in a garment, nor a base deviation from rectitude in time.

E.19

Wind indeed increases fire, but custom love.⁶

E.20

Those alone are dear to divinity, who are hostile to injustice.⁷

E.21

Those things which the body necessarily requires, are easily to be procured by all men, without labor and molestation; but those things to the attainment of which labor and molestation are requisite, are objects of desire, not to the body, but to depraved opinion. Aristoxenus Pythag. Stob. p. 132.

E.22

Of desire also, he [i. e. Pythagoras] said as follows: This passion is various, laborious, and very multiform. Of desires however, some are acquired and adventitious, but others are connascent. But he defined desire itself to be a certain tendency and impulse of the soul, and an appetite of a plenitude or presence of sense, or of an emptiness and absence of it, and of non-perception. He also said, that there are three most known species of erroneous and depraved desire, viz. the indecorous, the incommensurate, and the unseasonable. For desire is either immediately indecorous, troublesome, and illiberal; or it is not absolutely so, but is more vehement and lasting than is fit. Or in the third place, it is impelled when it is not proper; and to objects to which it ought not to tend. Ex Aristoxeni Pythag. Sententiis. Stob. p. 132.

E.23

Endeavour not to conceal your errors by words, but to remedy them by reproofs. Pythagoras. Stob. p. 146.

E.24

It is not so difficult to err, as not to reprove him who errs. Pythagoras. Stob. p. 147.

E.25

As a bodily disease cannot be healed, if it is concealed, or praised; thus also, neither can a remedy be applied to a diseased soul, which is badly guarded and protected. Pythagoras. Stob. p. 147.

E.26

The grace of freedom of speech, like beauty in season, is productive of greater delight.

E.27

It is not proper either to have a blunt sword, or to use freedom of speech ineffectually.

E.28

Neither is the sun to be taken from the world, nor freedom of speech from erudition.

E.29

As it is possible for one who is clothed with a sordid robe, to have a good habit of body; thus also he whose life is poor may possess freedom of speech.⁸

E.30

Be rather delighted with those that reprove, than with those that flatter you; but avoid flatterers, as worse than enemies. Pythagoras. Stob. p. 149.

E.31

The life of the avaricious resembles a funeral banquet. For though it has all things [requisite to a feast,] yet no one present rejoices. Stob. p. 155.⁹

E.32

Acquire continence as the greatest strength and wealth. Pythagoras. Stob. p. 156.

E.33

“Not frequently man from man,” is one of the exhortations of Pythagoras; by which he obscurely signifies, that it is not proper to be frequently engaged in venereal connexions. Stob. p. 156.

E.34

It is impossible that he can be free who is a slave to his passions. Pythagoras. Stob. 165.

E.35

Pythagoras said, that intoxication is the meditation of insanity. Stob. p. 165.

E.36

Pythagoras being asked, how a lover of wine might be cured of intoxication, answered, if he frequently surveys what his actions were when he was intoxicated. Stob. p. 165.

E.37

Pythagoras said, that it was either requisite to be silent, or to say something better than silence. Stob. p. 215.

E.38

Let it be more eligible to you to throw a stone in vain, than to utter an idle word. Pythagoras. Stob. p. 215.

E.39

Do not say a few things in many words, but much in a few words. Pythagoras. Stob. p. 216.

E.40

Genius is to men either a good or an evil dæmon. Epicharmus. Stob. p. 220.

E.41

Pythagoras being asked, how a man ought to conduct himself towards his country, when it had acted iniquitously with respect to him, replied, as to a mother. Stob. p. 227.

E.42

Travelling teaches a man frugality, and the way in which he may be sufficient to himself. For bread made of milk and flower, and a bed of grass, are the sweetest remedies of hunger and labor.

E.43

To the wise man every land is eligible as a place of residence; for the whole world is the country of the worthy soul.¹⁰ Stob. p. 231.

E.44

Pythagoras said, that luxury entered into cities in the first place, afterwards satiety, then lascivious insolence, and after all these

destruction. Stob. p. 247.

E.45

Pythagoras said, that of cities that was the best, which contained worthy men. Stob. p. 247.

E.46

Do those things which you judge to be beautiful, though in doing them you should be without renown. For the rabble is a bad judge of a good thing. [Despise therefore the reprehension of those whose praise you despise.] Demophilus. Stob. p. 310.¹¹

E.47

Those that do not punish bad men, wish that good men may be injured. Pythagoras. Stob. p. 321.

E.48

It is not possible for a horse to be governed without a bridle, or riches without prudence. Pythagoras. Stob. p. 513.

E.49

It is the same thing to think greatly of yourself in prosperity, as to contend in the race in a slippery road. Stob. p. 563.

E.50

There is not any gate of wealth so secure, which the opportunity of Fortune may not open. Stob. p. 563.¹²

E.51

Expel by reasoning the unrestrained grief of a torpid soul. Stob. p. 572.

E.52

It is the province of a wise man to bear poverty with equanimity. Stob. p. 572.¹³

E.53

Spare your life, lest you consume it with sorrow and care. Pythagoras. Stob. p. 616.

E.54

Nor will I be silent as to this particular, that it appeared both to Plato and Pythagoras, that old age was not to be considered with reference

to an egress from the present life, but to the beginning of a blessed life. From Phavorinus on Old Age. Stob. p. 585.

Two Extracts from Clemens Alexandrinus, in Stromat. lib. 3.
p. 413

C.1

The ancient theologists and priests testify that the soul is conjoined to the body through a certain punishment, and that it is buried in this body as in a sepulchre. Philolaus.

C.2

Whatever we see when awake is death; and when asleep, a dream. Pythagoras.

Select Sentences of Sextus the Pythagorean

S.1

To neglect things of the smallest consequence, is not the least thing in human life.

S.2

The wise man, and the despiser of wealth, resembles God.

S.3

Do not investigate the name of God, because you will not find it. For every thing which is called by a name, receives its appellation from that which is more worthy than itself,¹⁴ so that it is one person that calls, and another that hears. Who is it, therefore, that has given a name to God? God, however, is not a name to God, but an indication of what we conceive of him.

S.4

God is a light incapable of receiving its contrary [darkness.]

S.5

You have in yourself something similar to God, and therefore use yourself as the temple of God, on account of that which in you resembles God.

S.6

Honor God above all things, that he may rule over you.

S.7

Whatever you honor above all things, that which you so honor will have dominion over you. But if you give yourself to the domination of God, you will thus have dominion over all things.

S.8

The greatest honor which can be paid to God, is to know and imitate him.

S.9

There is not any thing, indeed, which wholly resembles God; nevertheless the imitation of him as much as possible by an inferior nature is grateful to him.

S.10

God, indeed, is not in want of any thing, but the wise man is in want of God alone. He, therefore, who is in want but of few things, and those necessary, emulates him who is in want of nothing.

S.11

Endeavour to be great in the estimation of divinity, but among men avoid envy.

S.12

The wise man whose estimation with men was but small while he was living, will be renowned when he is dead.

S.13

Consider all the time to be lost to you in which you do not think of divinity.

S.14

A good intellect is the choir of divinity.

S.15

A bad intellect is the choir of evil dæmons.

S.16

Honor that which is just, on this very account that it is just.

S.17

You will not be concealed from divinity when you act unjustly, nor even when you think of acting so.

S.18

The foundation of piety is continence; but the summit of piety is the love of God.

S.19

Wish that what is expedient and not what is pleasing may happen to you.

S.20

Such as you wish your neighbour to be to you, such also be you to your neighbours.

S.21

That which God gives you, no one can take away.

S.22

Neither do nor even think of that which you are not willing God should know.

S.23

Before you do any thing think of God, that his light may precede your energies.

S.24

The soul is illuminated by the recollection of deity.

S.25

The use of all animals as food is indifferent, but it is more rational to abstain from them.

S.26

God is not the author of any evil.

S.27

You should not possess more than the use of the body requires.

S.28

Possess those things which no one can take from you.

S.29

Bear that which is necessary, as it is necessary.

S.30

Ask those things of God which it is worthy of God to bestow.

S.31

The reason which is in you, is the light of your life.

S.32

Ask those things of God, which you cannot receive from man.

S.33

Wish that those things which labor ought to precede, may be possessed by you after labor.

S.34

Be not anxious to please the multitude.

S.35

It is not proper to despise those things of which we shall be in want after the dissolution¹⁵ of the body.

S.36

You should not ask of divinity that which, when you have obtained, you will not perpetually possess.

S.37

Accustom your soul after [it has conceived all that is great of] divinity, to conceive something great of itself.

S.38

Esteem nothing to be precious, which a bad man may take from you.

S.39

He is dear to divinity, who considers those things alone to be precious, which are esteemed to be so by divinity.

S.40

Every thing which is more than necessary to man, is hostile to him.

S.41

He who loves that which is not expedient, will not love that which is expedient.

S.42

The intellect of the wise man is always with divinity.

S.43

God dwells in the intellect of the wise man.

S.44

Every desire is insatiable, and therefore is always in want.

S.45

The wise man is always similar to himself.

S.46

The knowledge and imitation of divinity, are alone sufficient to beatitude.

S.47

Use lying as poison.

S.48

Nothing is so peculiar to wisdom as truth.

S.49

When you preside over men, remember that divinity also presides over you.

S.50

Be persuaded that the end of life, is to live conformably to divinity.

S.51

Depraved affections are the beginnings of sorrows.

S.52

An evil disposition is the disease of the soul; but injustice and impiety are the death of it.

S.53

Use all men in such a way, as if you were the common curator of all things after God.

S.54

He who uses mankind badly, uses himself badly.

S.55

Wish that you may be able to benefit your enemies.

S.56

Endure all things, in order that you may live conformably to God.

S.57

By honoring a wise man, you will honor yourself.

S.58

In all your actions place God before your eyes.¹⁶

S.59

You are permitted to refuse matrimony, in order that you may live incessantly adhering to God.¹⁷ If, however, as one knowing the battle, you are willing to fight, take a wife, and beget children.

S.60

To live, indeed, is not in our power, but to live rightly is.

S.61

Be unwilling to admit accusations against the man who is studious of wisdom.

S.62

If you wish to live with hilarity, be unwilling to do many things. For in a multitude of actions you will be minor.

S.63

Every cup should be sweet to you which extinguishes thirst.

S.64

Fly from intoxication as you would from insanity.

S.65

No good originates from the body.

S.66

Think that you suffer a great punishment when you obtain the object of corporeal desire; for the attainment of such objects never satisfies desire.

S.67

Invoke God as a witness to whatever you do.

S.68

The bad man does not think there is a providence.

S.69

Assert that which possesses wisdom in you, to be the [true] man.¹⁸

S.70

The wise man participates of God.

S.71

Where that which is wise in you resides, there also is your good.

S.72

That which is not noxious to the soul, is not noxious to man.

S.73

He who unjustly expels a wise man from the body, confers a benefit on him by his iniquity. For he thus becomes liberated as it were, from bonds.

S.74

The fear of death renders a man sad through the ignorance of his soul.

S.75

You will not possess intellect, till you understand that you have it.

S.76

Think that your body is the garment of your soul; and therefore preserve it pure.

S.77

Impure dæmons vindicate to themselves the impure soul.

S.78

Speak not of God to every man.

S.79

It is dangerous, and the danger is not small, to speak of God even things which are true.

S.80

A true assertion respecting God, is an assertion of God.

S.81

You should not dare to speak of God to the multitude.

S.82

He does not know God who does not worship him.

S.83

The man who is worthy of God is also a God among men.

S.84

It is better to have nothing, than to possess much and impart it to no one.

S.85

He who thinks that there is a God, and that nothing is taken care of by him, differs in no respect from him who does not believe that there is a God.

S.86

He honors God in the best manner who renders his intellect as much as possible similar to God.

S.87

If you injure no one, you will fear no one.

S.88

No one is wise who looks downward to the earth.

S.89

To lie is to deceive in life, and to be deceived.

S.90

Recognise what God is, and what that is in you which recognises God.

S.91

It is not death, but a bad life, that destroys the soul.

S.92

If you know him by whom you were made, you will know yourself.

S.93

It is not possible for a man to live conformable to divinity, unless he acts modestly, well, and justly.

S.94

Divine wisdom is true science.

S.95

You should not dare to speak of God to an impure soul.

S.96

The wise man follows God, and God follows the soul of the wise man.

S.97

A king rejoices in those whom he governs, and therefore God rejoices in the wise man. He who governs likewise, is inseparable from those whom he governs; and therefore God is inseparable from the soul of the wise man, which he defends and governs.

S.98

The wise man is governed by God, and on this account is blessed.

S.99

A scientific knowledge of God causes a man to use few words.

S.100

To use many words when speaking of God, produces an ignorance of God.

S.101

The man who possesses a knowledge of God, will not be very ambitious.

S.102

The erudite,¹⁹ chaste, and wise soul, is the prophet of the truth of God.

S.103

Accustom yourself always to look to Divinity.

S.104

A wise intellect is the mirror of God.

Pythagoric Sentences, from the Protreptics of Iamblichus²⁰

I.1

As we live through soul, it must be said that by the virtue of this we live well; just as because we see through the eyes, we see well through the virtue of these.

I.2

It must not be thought that gold can be injured by rust, or virtue by baseness.

I.3

We should betake ourselves to virtue as to an inviolable temple, in order that we may not be exposed to any ignoble insolence of soul with respect to our communion with, and continuance in life.

L.4

We should confide in Virtue as in a chaste wife; but trust to Fortune as to an inconstant mistress.

L.5

It is better that virtue should be received accompanied with poverty, than wealth with violence; and frugality with health, than veracity with disease.

L.6

An abundance of nutriment is noxious to the body; but the body is preserved when the soul is disposed in a becoming manner.

L.7

It is equally dangerous to give a sword to a madman, and power to a depraved man.

L.8

As it is better for a part of the body which contains purulent matter to be burnt, than to continue in the state in which it is, thus also it is better for a depraved man to die than to live.

L.9

The theorems of philosophy are to be enjoyed as much as possible, as if they were ambrosia and nectar. For the pleasure arising from them is genuine, incorruptible, and divine. They are also capable of producing magnanimity; and though they cannot make us eternal beings, yet they enable us to obtain a scientific knowledge of eternal natures.²¹

L.10

If vigor of sensation is considered by us to be an eligible thing, we should much more strenuously endeavour to obtain prudence; for it is as it were the sensitive vigor of the practical intellect which we contain. And as through the former we are not deceived in sensible

perceptions, so through the latter we avoid false reasoning in practical affairs.

L.11

We shall venerate Divinity in a proper manner, if we render the intellect that is in us pure from all vice, as from a certain stain.

L.12

A temple, indeed, should be adorned with gifts, but the soul with disciplines.

L.13

As the lesser mysteries are to be delivered before the greater, thus also discipline must precede philosophy.

L.14

The fruits of the earth, indeed, are annually imparted, but the fruits of philosophy at every part of the year.

L.15

As land is especially to be attended to by him who wishes to obtain from it the most excellent fruit, thus also the greatest attention should be paid to the soul, in order that it may produce fruit worthy of its nature.

Notes

¹ The above sentences are from Stobæi Sententiæ, p. 3. (the edition that of 1609,) and are ascribed to Pythagoras.

² The above seven sentences are to be found in p. 4. of Stobæus, and as it appears to me are erroneously ascribed to Socrates. For I conceive them to have been written either by Democrates or Demophilus.

³ Stob. p. 48.

⁴ Hence the dogma of the Stoics derived its origin, that the wise man is independent of Fortune.

⁵ Stob. p. 65. These three sentences are ascribed to Pythagoras.

⁶ Stob. p. 80. These two sentences are ascribed to Socrates, but I have no doubt originally formed a part of the sentences of Demophilus.

⁷ Stob. p. 104. This sentence is ascribed to Democritus in Stobæus, but has doubtless either Democrates or Demophilus for its author.

⁸ Stob. p. 147. The above four sentences, are in Stobæus ascribed to Socrates; but I refer them either to Democrates or Demophilus.

⁹ This sentence in Stobæus is ascribed to Socrates, as is also the one which immediately precedes it, viz. “The wealth of the avaricious man, like the sun descending under the earth, delights no living thing.” But as this sentence is to be found among the Similitudes of Demophilus, there can be no doubt of the other belonging to the same work.

¹⁰ This and the preceding sentence, are in Stobæus ascribed to Democritus, but I attribute them to Democrates or Demophilus.

¹¹ This sentence in Stobæus is ascribed to Pythagoras, but, excepting the part within the brackets, is to be found among the sentences of Demophilus.

¹² This sentence in Stobæus, is ascribed to Democritus, and that immediately preceding it, to Socrates; but I ascribe both of them to Democrates, or Demophilus.

¹³ This and the preceding sentences, together with two other sentences that accompany them, are in Stobæus ascribed to Democritus; but as the other two are to be found in the Collection of Democrates, there can be no doubt that all of them are from the same author.

¹⁴ For as every cause of existence to a thing, is better than that thing, so far as the one is cause and the other effect; thus also that which gives a name to any thing is better than the thing named, so far as it is named, i. e. so far as pertains to its possession of a name. For the nominator is the cause, and the name the effect.

¹⁵ In the Latin it is “post *dispositionem* corporis.” But for *dispositionem* it is evidently necessary to read *dissolutionem*.

¹⁶ This is conformable to the well-known Pythagoric precept, “Follow God.”

¹⁷ “We can by no other means,” (says Porphyry De Abstinen. lib. I.) “obtain the true end of a contemplative, intellectual life than by *adhering* to God, if I may be allowed the expression, as if fastened by a nail, at the same time being torn away and separated from body and corporeal delights; having procured safety from our deeds, and not from the mere attention to words.”

¹⁸ But intellect is the recipient of wisdom, and therefore intellect is the true man. This also is asserted by Aristotle.

¹⁹ In the Latin *fidelis*; but as Ruffinus, the Latin translator of these sentences, frequently adulterates the true meaning of Sextus, by substituting one word for another, I have no doubt that in this sentence the original was πεπαιδευμενος *eruditus*, and not πιστος *fidelis*. My reason for so thinking is, that in one of the sentences of Demophilus it is said, “that the life of *ignorant* men is a disgrace,” των αμαθων ονειδος ειναι τον βιον; and this in the sentences of Sextus is, “*Hominum infidelium vita, opprobrium est.*” If, therefore, Ruffinus translates αμαθων, *infidelium*, there is every reason to suppose that he would translate πεπαιδευμενος, *fidelis*.

²⁰ Several of these sentences as published by Arcerius, are in a very defective state; but which, as the learned reader will perceive, I have endeavoured to amend in my translation of them.

²¹ *The theorems of philosophy are to be enjoyed, as much as possible, as if they were ambrosia and nectar, &c. &c.*

This Sentence in the original of Arcerius is as follows: των κατα φιλοσοφian θεωρηματων απολαυστεον, εφ’ οσον οιον, καθαπερ αμβροσιας και νεκταρος ακηρατον τε γαρ το απ’ αυτων ηδυ και το θειον το μεγαλοψυχον δυναται τε ποιειν, και ει μη αϊδιους, αϊδιων γε επιστημονας.

In the edition of the Protreptics by Kiessling, which I did not see, till the greater part of this work was printed, σοφian is substituted for φιλοσοφian, but in my opinion very erroneously; and this German editor, from not perceiving the necessity of reading ακηρατον τε γαρ το απ’ αυτων ηδυ και θειον, το μεγαλοψυχον, κ. λ. instead of retaining the reading of Arcerius, has made nonsense of this part of the Sentence. For his version of it is: “*Nam et sincera est eorum dulcedo, et divinam naturam, animum magnum efficere possunt.*”